What's That Mushroom?

I'll tell you when I can't tell.

A UK fungi identification app whose design principle is admitting when it does not know.

It never says a mushroom is edible, and it does not say anything is inedible either -- there is no such category in it. It records a hazard where one is on record, and shows nothing at all where none is.

Where the leading candidates straddle a known dangerous pair it refuses to choose, says so, and asks for the one piece of evidence that would settle it.

These are the working client against the real server. The classifier has not been trained yet, so the species shown come from a placeholder that produces consistent but meaningless rankings. Everything around it -- the refusal logic, the question selection, the hazard display, the consent text -- is real, and is what these pages are about.

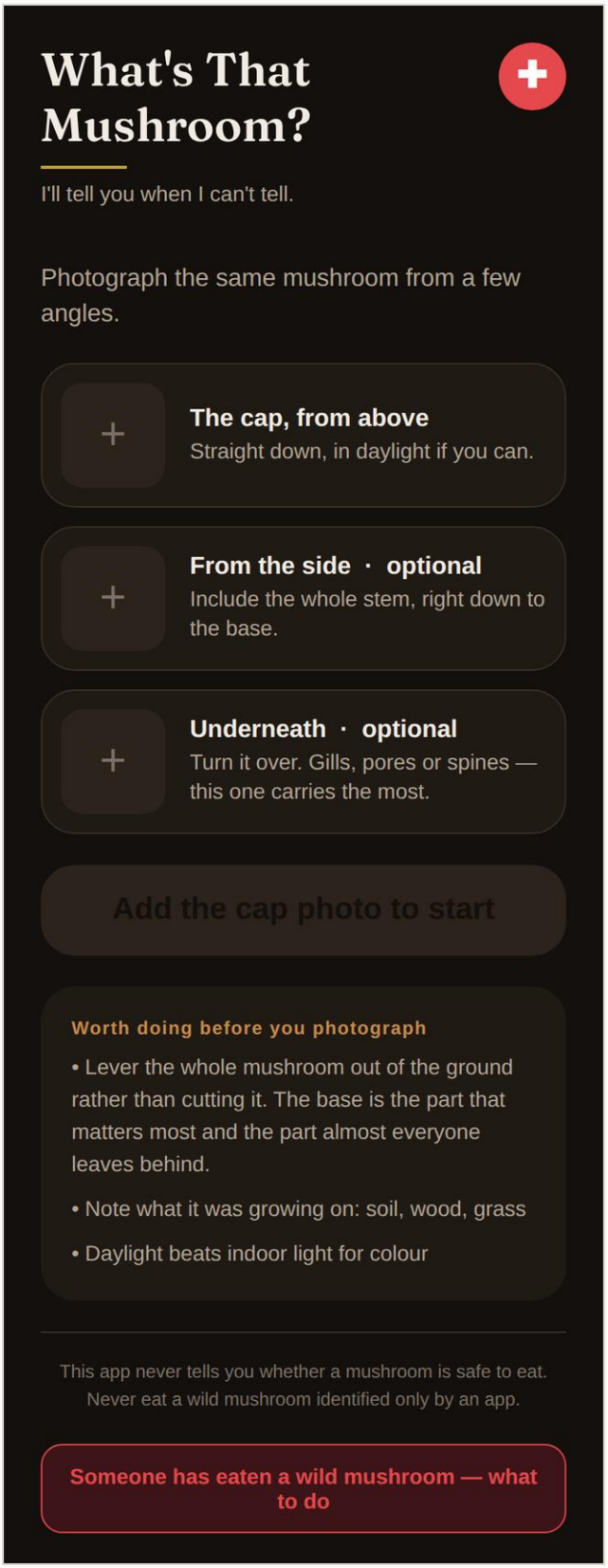
244 British species. 112 lethal lookalike pairs. The toxicity data and the names are what I am asking a mycologist to check.

Martin Hawkes · The Shropshire Forager

Screens captured 19 October 2026 from the running client

The front page

No photograph of a mushroom, nothing to browse, no species of the day. The tagline is the product claim. The red cross goes straight to emergency guidance: hardcoded, works offline, and sits above the consent gate, because someone whose child has eaten something is not going to complete an onboarding flow.



What a user agrees to before first use

Every statement is ticked on its own. There is no accept-all, because one blanket agreement is a formality and a formality is what people learn to tap past. Three statements are conditional on the service's real state, so the last one -- that the reference data has not been checked by a mycologist -- disappears by itself the day that stops being true. The version is a hash of the text, so changing a word re-asks everyone who already agreed.

Someone has eaten a wild mushroom — what to do

Before you use this

This app exists because the other ones answer every question. It will often tell you that it cannot identify what you have photographed, and that is the app working, not failing.

It will never tell you that a mushroom is safe to eat. No app can. People are killed every year by mushrooms that were identified confidently and wrongly, and the species responsible have ordinary lookalikes that experienced foragers collect on purpose.

- ✓ **I understand this app will never tell me a mushroom is safe to eat.**
  There is no such category in it. It names what it can and warns about recorded hazards. Where there is no hazard on record it says nothing at all, which is not the same as saying it is safe.

- ✓ **I understand a photograph cannot rule out a deadly lookalike.**
  The features that separate the dangerous species from their ordinary lookalikes are usually underground, underneath, or only visible hours later in a spore print.

- ✓ **I will not eat a wild mushroom on the strength of what this app tells me.**
  An identification here is a starting point for a person who already knows what they are doing, and nothing more than that.

- ✓ **I understand this build has no trained model, and the identifications it produces are placeholders.**
  The classifier has not been trained yet. Results come from a stub that produces consistent but meaningless answers, so that everything around it can be built and tested.

- ✓ **I understand the percentages shown are not probabilities.**
  Calibration has not been fitted. Until it is, a number is an ordering between candidates and nothing more -- 80% does not mean eight times in ten.

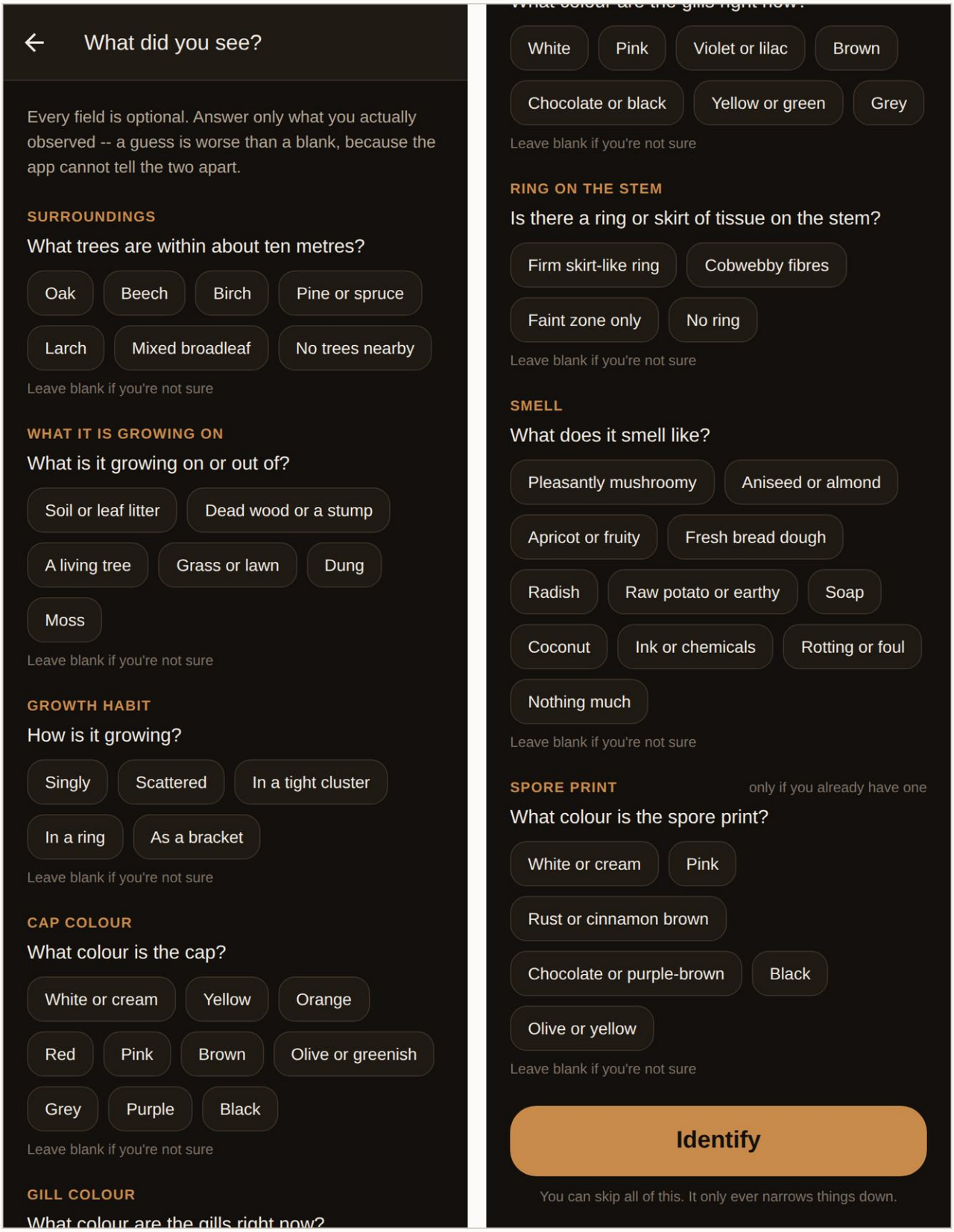
- ✓ **I understand the reference data has not been checked by a mycologist.**
  Which species are dangerous, which are confused with which, and what separates them are compiled from standard references and have not been reviewed by a qualified person. Errors in that data become errors in every answer.

I understand — continue

Kept on this phone. There is no account and nothing is uploaded.

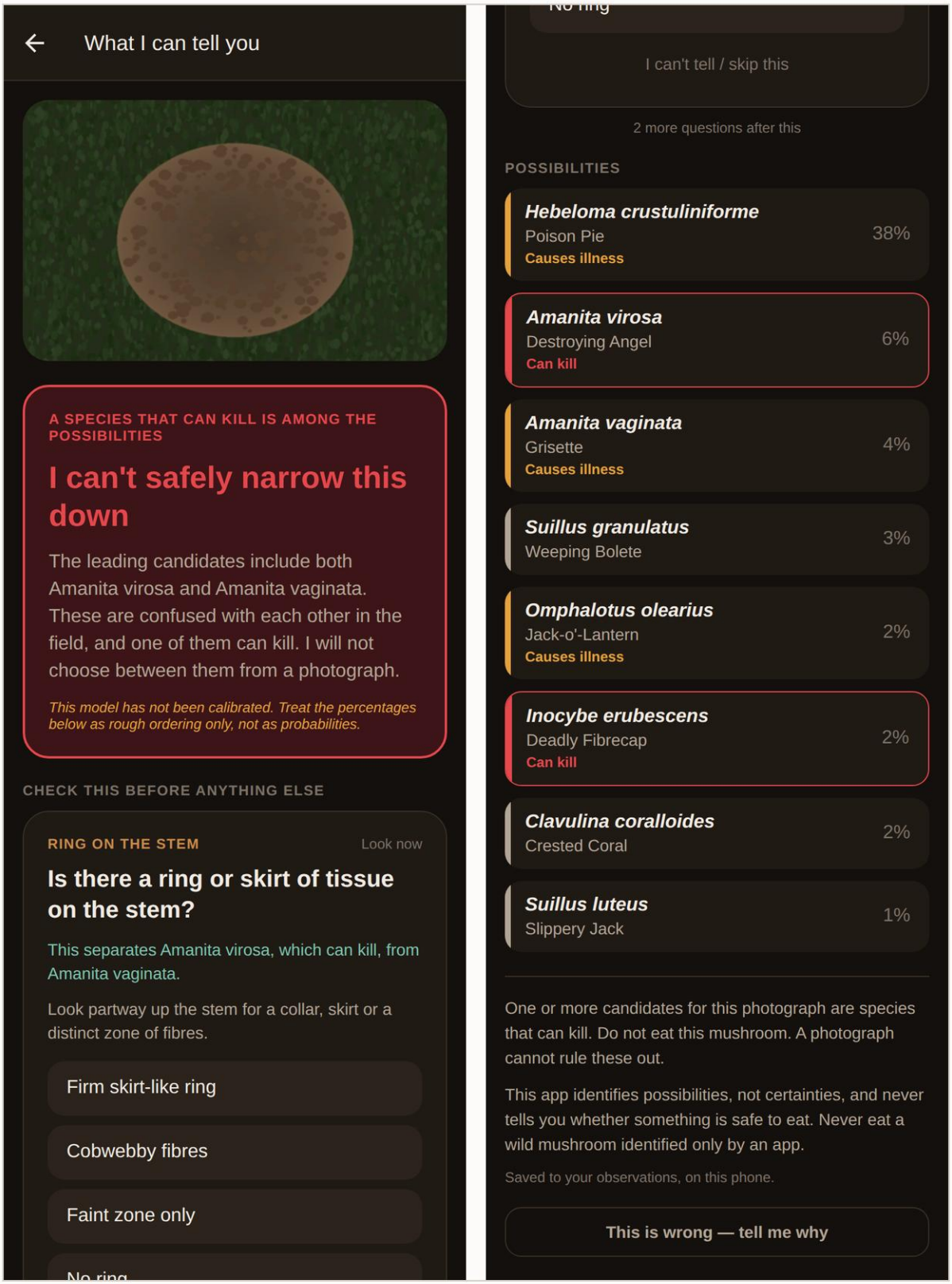
What it asks before it answers

Optional, every one of them, and the screen says so twice. A guess is worse than a blank here, because the app cannot tell the two apart -- so the wording invites a blank rather than rewarding completeness. These notes are fed to the model as inputs, not stored as decoration.



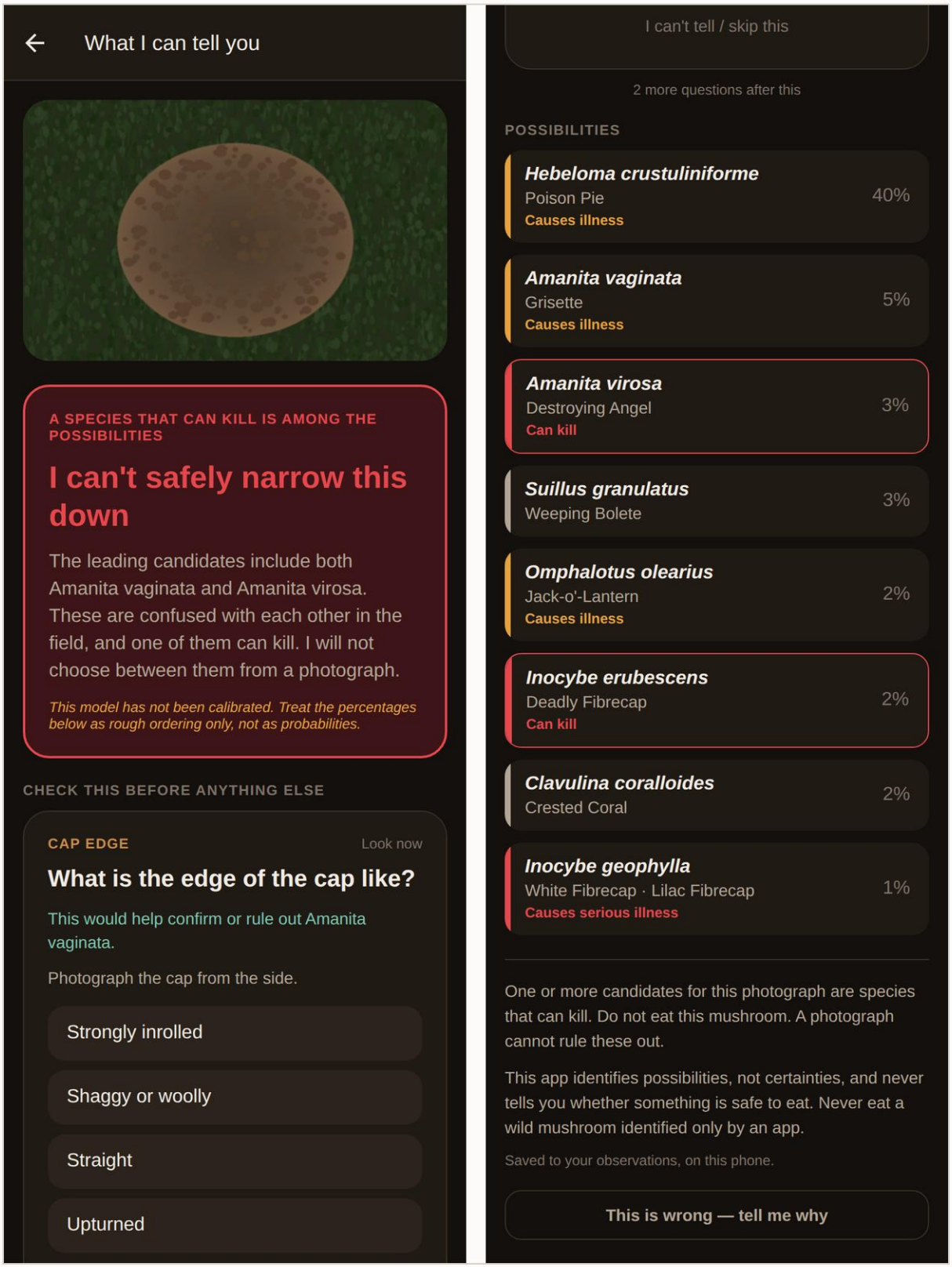
The verdict screen, refusing

The leading candidate is a Poison Pie at 40 per cent. The app does not lead with it. It leads with the refusal, because two of the candidates are a destroying angel and a grisette, and it will not choose between a lethal species and its lookalike from a photograph. Below the refusal is the question that would settle it, with the reason it is being asked.



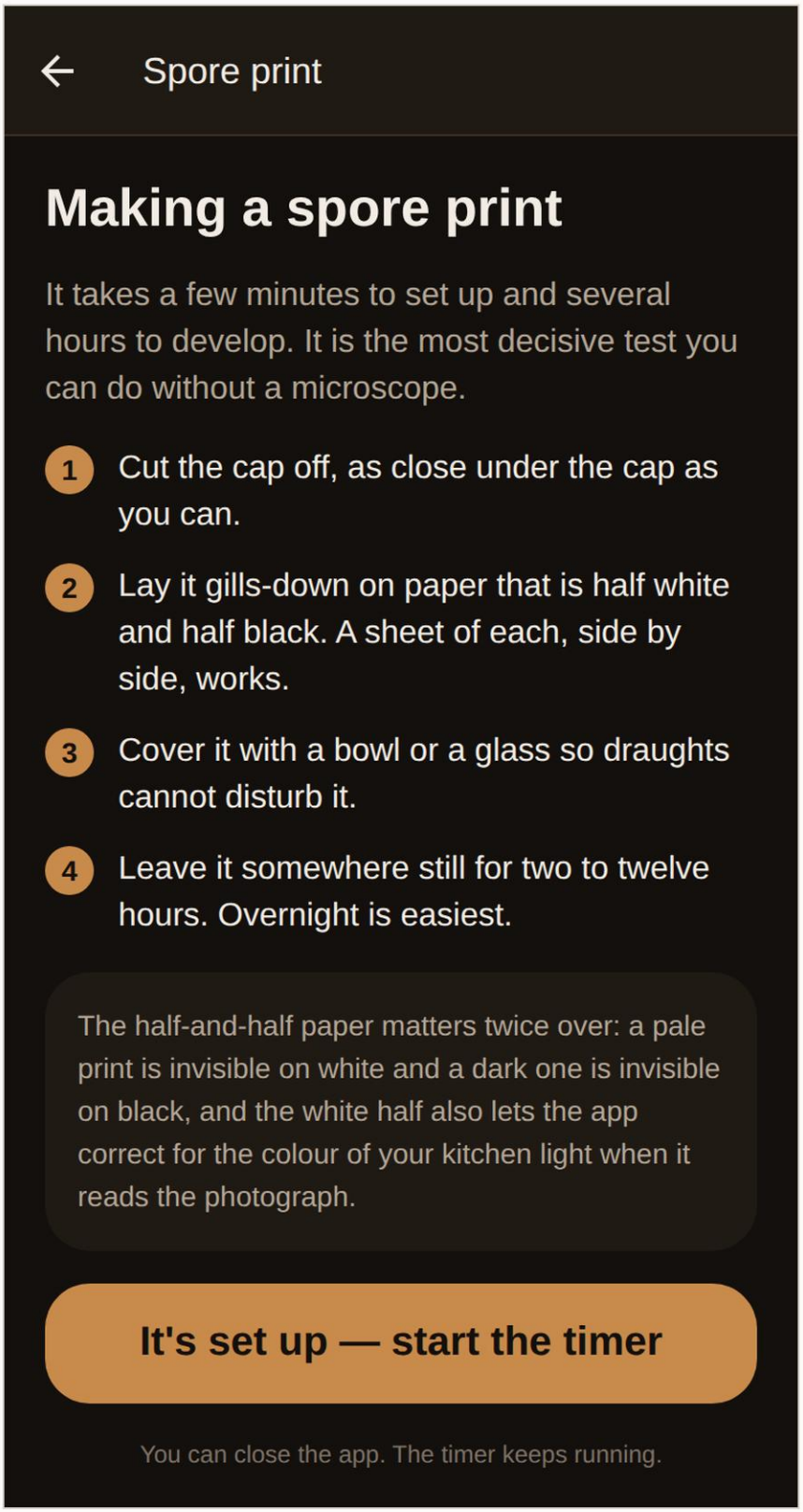
Why the refusal holds at three per cent

After one answer the ranking has moved and Amanita virosa is down to 3 per cent -- still outlined, still marked 'Can kill'. The verdict does not change. A small probability of death is not rounded away, and the rule is not a threshold on the leading candidate. The 40 per cent species above it carries no highlight at all: a hazard is shown where one is on record, and nothing is shown where none is.



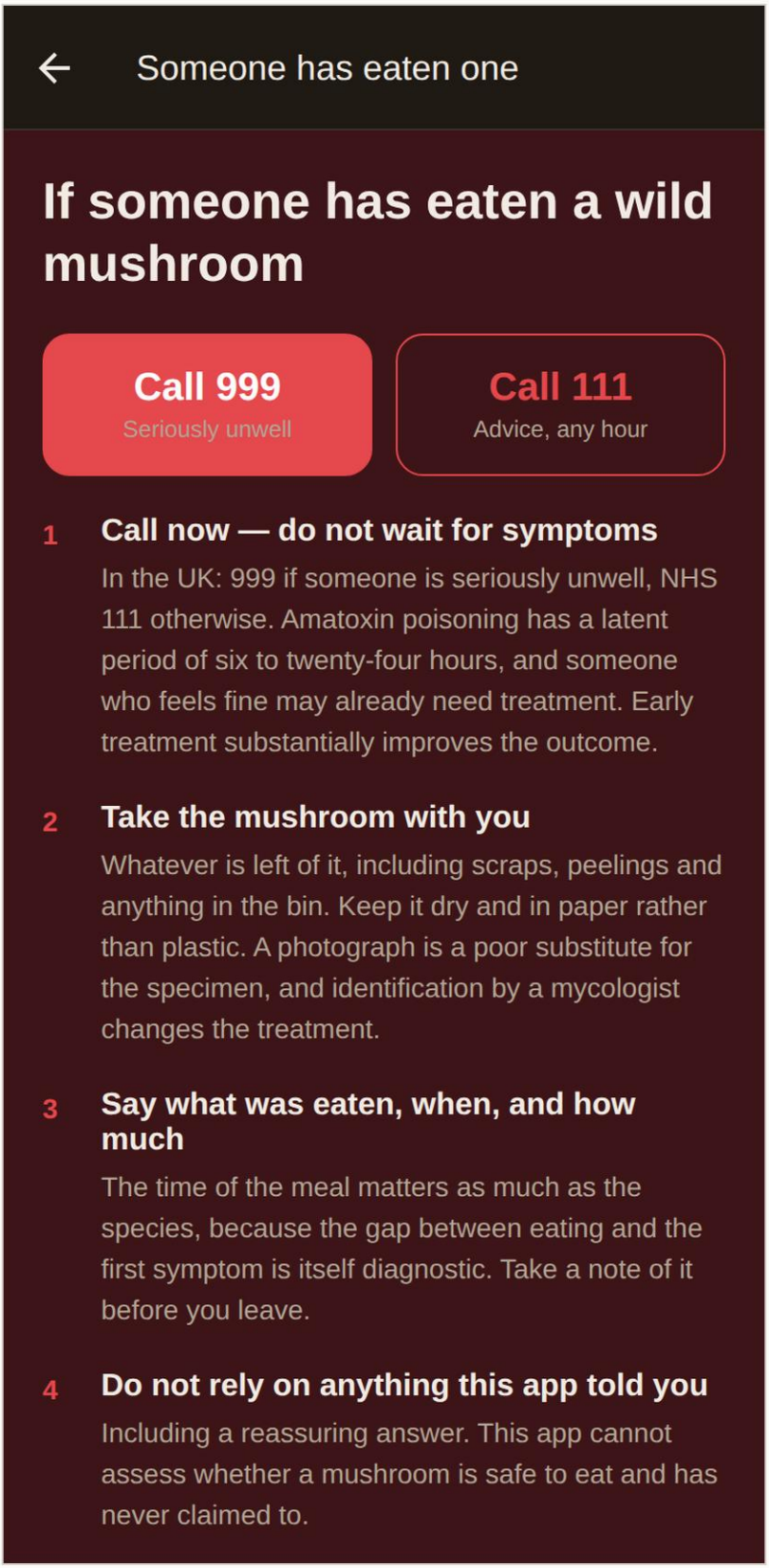
The spore print, walked through

Spore colour is the most decisive test available without a microscope, and no consumer app guides it. Half white and half black paper, because a pale print is invisible on white and a dark one on black -- and the white half lets the server correct for kitchen light when it reads the photograph. The timer is a stored timestamp, so it survives the app being closed for the twelve hours this takes.



The one screen that must never fail

Hardcoded, offline, reachable from every screen and from before consent. It leads with the latent period, because someone who feels fine may already need treatment, and it says to bring the specimen rather than a photograph. The last item tells the user not to rely on anything the app said, including a reassuring answer.



What a saved record may say later

The same refusal, weeks later. On the result screen the app names both halves of the pair, because the refusal is on the screen beside them. In a list it names neither: two species in a scrolling history is two guesses to choose between. Stored confidences carry the model version and calibration state they were produced under -- that is what 'one thing to know about this record' is reporting.

